Try it out

Claude Code on a project of your own

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Where we are today

	What this course is for
	Getting it running
→	**Try it out** ← you are here
	The terminal, and how to read what Claude does
	Lunch
	A working day with Claude Code
	What the model reads, predicts and weighs
	A model, a menu, and a loop
	It doesn’t remember. It’s handed everything again.
	Wrap, done at 17:00

Learning objectives

After this block you will be able to:

1. **Use** Claude Code on a project of your own.
2. **Describe** what Claude did and what you did not expect.

15 to 20 minutes on your own work

Exercise · 15–20 min

1. **Pick a project whose files may all be sent to the AI provider.** Everything Claude reads goes there. No licensed data, no survey data about people, and no coauthor's draft.
2. **Copy its folder and start Claude Code in the copy.** If something goes wrong, the original is untouched.
3. **Ask Claude for something you would do anyway.**
4. **When Claude Code asks before running something, read what it will run.** Not sure? Choose No and ask Claude. In Auto, Claude Code asks less often. Switch to Manual with `Shift+Tab` to be asked before edits and most commands.

You ask. Claude writes. You read it and decide.

Stuck? Raise your hand. No idea where to start? The next slide has ideas.

Ideas for a first request

Exercise

Your files

> Explain what is in this folder and what each script does.

> Search for where the sample is restricted, and show me the line.

Make something

> Make a table of summary statistics from the data file in this folder.

Review

> Read my draft in this folder and list the three weakest points of its argument.

Discuss

> Is my research question answerable with the data in this folder? Argue both sides.

Search the web

> Find three recent papers on this project's topic, with a link to each.

Meanwhile, my own project

Demo

While you work, I start a project of my own on the projector. When you raise your hand, I stop.

The idea: when Claude makes everyone's work look alike, the work says less about who is good. Employers then lean on other signals, such as a name or a school. So AI could raise discrimination in hiring.

Today I only set it up, as you do: a folder, and Claude's first view of the question.

What did you try?

- What did you ask?
- What did Claude do?
- **What did Claude do that you did not expect?**

Keep your own project going

Keep the project you just tried open for the rest of the course, all four days.

At points inside and between blocks, you get a few minutes for it. Give Claude the next request, read what Claude did, or try what the last block showed.

When a discussion runs long, those minutes get shorter. When there is time, they get longer.

A starter kit

A folder that sets Claude Code up for research work: standing instructions, a way to pick up each project where you stopped, skills for analysis, papers and review, and a few commands.

Everything this course teaches is already set up in it. We open each part when the course gets to it.

Download it now: `github.com/fgaertner-teaching/claude-vanilla`: **Code**, then **Download ZIP**, then unpack it anywhere.

Give it to your Claude

Open a terminal in the unpacked folder, start Claude Code there, and switch to **Manual** with `Shift+Tab`. Then ask:

> This folder is a starter kit for Claude Code. Read it and compare it with what I already have in ~/.claude. Is it useful for me, and what should I adopt? Change nothing until I say so.

Claude needs a few minutes. We go on with the next block meanwhile.

When the answer is there, tell Claude what to adopt, and read each change before you approve it.